C1 Reading

Working out meaning from context

Guess unknown words from the clues around them instead of reaching for a dictionary.

Advanced texts always contain some unfamiliar words. Strong readers do not stop at each one; they use the context to work out a meaning that is good enough to keep reading.

Clue	Example	What it tells you
Definition or rephrasing	*The drug is **efficacious**, that is, it works.*	The meaning is given directly.
Contrast	*Unlike her **gregarious** sister, Maya prefers to be alone.*	The opposite of preferring to be alone: sociable.
Example	***Arid** regions, such as deserts, get little rain.*	Very dry.
Cause and result	*The talks **foundered**, so no agreement was signed.*	Failed.
Word parts	***un-precedent-ed***	Never happened before.

Three-step check. Decide the word class (noun, verb, adjective), decide if it is positive or negative, then try a simple word in its place and see if the sentence still makes sense.

Common mistake. Guessing from how a word looks alone. *Inflammable* looks like "not flammable", but it means "easily set on fire". Always check your guess against the sentence.

Practice

Work out the meaning of the word in bold and name the clue you used.

1. The manager was **adamant**: no matter how much we argued, she would not change her decision.
2. Most of his novels are long, but this one is remarkably **terse**.
3. The town relies on **perennial** crops, plants such as fruit trees that grow back every year.
4. Prices rose so **precipitously** that many families could no longer afford bread.
5. Her **misgivings** about the plan proved right when the project collapsed.

▼ **Show answers**

1. Refusing to change one's mind (cause and result: "would not change her decision").
2. Short, using few words (contrast with "long").
3. Living or growing for many years (example and definition: "fruit trees that grow back every year").
4. Very suddenly and steeply (result: families could no longer afford bread).
5. Doubts or worries (result: the plan failed, so she was right to worry; word parts: *mis-* + *giving*).